

Exploring financial agency in neoliberal urban design

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Introduction

Ethos refers to the guiding beliefs and ideals that characterise the behaviour of a certain group of individuals. In this case, the ethos of the urban designer refers to the set of beliefs and attitudes of urban design practitioners when deciding on urban form and space shaping. As a practice-oriented discipline, the decisions made by urban designers have physical representations in space which are long-lasting in urban life. For Alexander Cuthbert, urban designers must deal with the political sphere and understand that every single change in space is a political action (A. R. Cuthbert, 2006, 2011). As Sorkin argues, urban design has assumed an orthodox which has epistemological implications as urban theory has not advanced towards more imaginative ways of seeing urban life (Sorkin, 2013). This condition of this discipline field may be a consequence of the assumption of urban design as an economic driver only (F. Vergara-Perucich, 2019), which implied different methodological changes (Carmona & Tiesdell, 2007; Larice & Macdonald, 2011). Urban design, as a disciplinary field, cannot be subsumed under a total methodology that eliminates the richness of conflicts for defining the methods to study the urban form (A. Cuthbert, 2007). Generalisations on urban design are discussable because methodologies are not fixed but also because each city has diversity and complexities that are unique. However, many times the analysis of urban design processes neglects the economic features of its practice, motivations, and social effects. Therefore, what happens when the ethos of urban designers embraces the aims of neoliberalism? How the complexity of neoliberal urban processes can be tackled through research strategies? This chapter offers an approach to this question.

Neoliberalism as a concept refers to laissez-faire economics, whose goals are economic liberalisation, defence of private property rights, governmental austerity, and free trade (Azevedo et al., 2019; Bourdieu, 1998). Neoliberalism situates the private (individual, enterprises) at the centre of economic activities.

At a base level we can say that when we refer to 'neoliberalism', we are generally referring to the new political, economic and social arrangements within society that emphasize market relations, re-tasking the role of the state, and individual responsibility. Most

scholars tend to agree that neoliberalism is broadly defined as the extension of competitive markets into all areas of life, including the economy, politics and society.

(Springer, 2016, p. 2)

In practice, neoliberalism is also a governmental model that eliminates control over prices, deregulates capital markets, fosters free international trade, and advances toward the privatisation of social security (Boas & Gans-Morse, 2009). David Harvey's definition of neoliberalism says that neoliberalism is 'either a utopian project to realise a theoretical design for the reorganisation of international capitalism or a political project to re-establish the conditions for capital accumulation and to restore the power of economic elites' (Harvey, 2005, p. 19). Neoliberalism fosters individualism, and one of the main spatial expressions of individualised space is the dwelling with its spatial representation: housing. Under neoliberalism, the push for homeownership by governments has been a common feature (Rossi & Vanolo, 2015). Starting in the early 1990s, after the Washington consensus, banks reduced the requirements for credits on mortgages, which facilitated access to homeownership at a time that involved the financial sector more actively in the production of spaces (Fernandez & Aalbers, 2016). The access of low-income communities to multiple mortgages without financial background and the coercion of the financial sector to maximise the earnings from the housing market were the main causes of the great financial crisis of 2008 (Follain & Giertz, 2012). Indeed, the greatest crisis facing neoliberalism emerged from the processes of space production and the participation of financial institutions in the process (Allon & Redden, 2012; Christophers, 2019; Rolnik, 2013). Therefore, a critical theorisation of neoliberalism from the perspective of urban design seems like a suitable approach to unpacking these ideological project-affected cities. Because of the subprime crisis of 2008 and the real estate bubbles in Europe, neoliberalism entered a profound crisis of credibility, and after the pandemic, it will face a new epistemological crisis because of the incapacity of free-market economics to provide universal welfare in times of planetary threat. Also, climate emergency causes point to the way of production of neoliberal society as the main driver of global warming, so the survival of neoliberalism to its contradictions is at stake. As Slavoj Žižek said, it seems easier to imagine the end of life on Earth than a modest transformation in the neoliberal modes of production (Žižek, 2012). However, nowadays it seems that global leaders are open to changing this way of thinking.

Consequently, the manifold forms and pathways of neoliberal urbanization should be seen not as coherent, sustainable solutions to the embedded regulatory dilemmas and contradictions of contemporary capitalism, but rather as deeply contradictory restructuring strategies that are significantly destabilizing inherited landscapes of urban governance and socioeconomic regulation.

(Peck et al., 2009, p. 64)

Neoliberalisation of urban design accelerated the process through which the city became a simple commodity (Stanek, 2008), so enquiring into its spatial forms may represent a method for contesting the adverse effects of this ideology in urban life. John Rennie Short explains that the neoliberal agenda has undercut the funding for urban design in the sense that the public sector could advance toward providing a good life through urban spaces (Short, 2006). For him, urban disciplines have been refashioned by neoliberalism in order to generate economic growth through urban development.

An urban design model under a neoliberal regime was implemented for the first time in Chile, particularly in Santiago, by a new urban policy introduced in 1979

(F. Vergara-Perucich & Boano, 2020a), which transformed the ethos of urban designers in Chile, affecting their decision-making criteria to subsume urban form to its profitability (F. Vergara-Perucich & Boano, 2020b). To contribute to a broader discussion on the methodologies of urban design, the chapter didactically introduces a way to analyse how profitability helped to shape urban space in the case of Santiago de Chile to unravel the contradictions of neoliberal urbanism employing its tools for illuminating its flaws.

Methods

This chapter takes as a case study the real estate development in Santiago de Chile to analyse how this process delivers highly profitable outcomes while also producing gentrification and segregation. This chapter also enlightens how the urban form suffers from the financialised model of housing provision, in which the dwellings are used as an investment rather than for living in (J. F. Vergara-Perucich & Aguirre-Núñez, 2019b). The data used comes from the environmental declarations of real estate companies, the Private Property Register of Santiago, and the National Institute of Statistics.

Santiago de Chile is a good case for illustrating the neoliberal contradiction as it was the first global capital where a neoliberal urban policy was implemented (Bohoslavsky et al., 2021; Brenner et al., 2012; Harvey, 2005). This urban policy relied on free-market economics to shape the city that produces a highly segregated urban space (Borsdorf et al., 2016; Figueroa et al., 2021; Sabatini et al., 2017; Toro & Orozco, 2018), triggering gentrification (Contreras & Venegas, 2016; R. C. Hidalgo, 2020; Lopez-Morales, 2011) and reproducing urban inequality (Martínez & Santibañez, 2015; Rodríguez et al., 2014; Ruiz-Tagle, 2016). While the profitability of urban investments in the city is very high (J. F. Vergara-Perucich & Aguirre-Núñez, 2019a; J. F. Vergara-Perucich & Boano, 2019), the benefits of free-market urban economics have not been equally distributed and the practitioners are due to advance in understanding their role in this process to have the power to revert these socio-spatial contradictions.

The method has a first statistical section that aims to know the potential profitability expectations set by real estate agents to decide to invest in projects found in the city. For this purpose, a model was developed that consists of three parts: A construction cost model, an income model and finally a general cash flow model of the projects under study. In Chile, this is the mechanism most used by real estate companies when deciding whether to invest in a housing project or not. Subsequently, the second section provides evidence of how these profit-driven urban designs generate social impacts in this city, using literature on the case of Santiago de Chile.

The method assesses the total financial efficiency of the investment. This profit is analysed through the internal rate of return (IRR) and the net present value (NPV). The construction cost model is based on a budget estimation equivalent to the replacement cost validation model of the Chilean Internal Revenue Service (SII for its Spanish initials). It is considered that the construction of the building takes one floor per month in advance. Time value is fundamental for correctly assessing the profitability calculations of each analysed real estate project.

The applied method is based on Vergara-Perucich and Aguirre (2019). The NPV is a procedure that calculates the present value of a certain number of future financial flows generated by an investment. It is calculated by applying a current discount rate to all future cash flows, simulating what the gains would be if the cash flows were brought to the present to compare these gains with the initial investment. The discount rate (d) is the result of the product between the Weighted Average Cost of Capital (WACC) and the inflation rate for the period. For these projects, a discount rate of 12% has been applied based on the reference

usually used in Chilean real estate business evaluation (Simian & Niklitschek, 2017). If the NPV is greater than 0 (i.e., exceeds the initial investment), the project is considered a recommended investment. The NPV formula is the following:

$$NPV = \sum_j^n [-I + \frac{R_j}{(1+i)^{-n}}]$$

wherein,

R_j = net cash flow in the period j

n = number of periods

i = discount rate (12%)

The IRR tests the mean of the return on investment to determine whether the opportunity is worth the effort. The higher the IRR, the better. Its calculation is based on the following formula:

$$IRR, \text{ such that, } \sum_{j=0}^n \frac{R_{jn}}{(1+IRR)^n} = NPV = 0$$

wherein,

R_j = net cash flow in the ' j ' period

NPV = net present value

IRR = internal rate of return

The data sources are the following:

- 1 Conservador de Bienes Raíces de Santiago, a public entity that registers property transactions in the city, indicates the personal data of those who carry out the transactions, values, dimensions, and general characteristics of each property. This information was obtained from data collected by InCiti.
- 2 Speed of sale of the properties to determine their construction times, prepared based on data from the Chilean Chamber of Construction and the background of project progress collected by InCiti.
- 3 The definitive amounts of investment by the projects were not available for each of the cases, but it has served to test the veracity of the data obtained from other sources to review whether the announced investments are following the calculated returns. For this information, the Environmental Assessment Service of the Ministry of Environment has been consulted.
- 4 For the estimation of construction costs, I have developed a calculation based on data obtained from the ONDAC catalogue of construction activities and the estimation tables developed by the Internal Revenue Service and the Ministry of Housing and Urban Development. Depending on the volume constructed, I have used a construction value of USD/m² estimated at 600 for construction above ground level; and 500 USD/m² for construction underground. These values are net.
- 5 To estimate the income from sales projects, the commercial value advertised on specialised websites (portalinmobiliario.com and toctoc.com) has been used, contrasting

- it with the transaction information indicated in InCiti's databases and in the advertisements of the companies that commercialised their works.
- 6 To the final investment costs, the expenses corresponding to advertising and sales, consulting, and project design have been added.
 - 7 To illustrate the role of financial entities and their impact on the profitability of a project when it requests bank loans to execute the works, a set of results has been developed that expose some projects with bank financing indicating their percentage of total investment and others only based on own resources.

From the Social Ministry information, it has been possible to determine if the household nearby where these projects are constructed could pay the housing prices or not. A simulation of a 30 years mortgage at an annual rate of 4% was taken as a reference to see the monthly cost of living in the housing units assessed. Finally, the projects assessed allowed us to identify if within the building there are single owners who purchased more than three housing units, assuming that if one person buys more than two units in the same building, its purpose is using housing as an investment rather than for living in it. The results are presented in the following section. As the results on profit provide evidence of the profitability of the business, the third section elaborates on how this information complements other findings from different approaches and reflects on the agency of urban designers in order to overcome the subsumption of their practice to the financial understanding of the city.

Case study: housing profit in Santiago de Chile

Eight real estate projects located in different districts of Santiago de Chile were analysed. These eight projects were chosen because they had a similar architectural typology, were built in 2017, and because they had all the financial data for each one, from building permits to flyers advertising the sale of the flats. This level of detail in the information made it possible to reconstruct the economic flow of each case. These projects are high-rise housing buildings whose urban impact requires an environmental impact statement, so part of their data is available for public consultation. As a summary of the cases studied, the average land value is found to be 325 USD/sqm, for a height composed of an average of 25 floors. On average, each of the eighth buildings analysed offered 590 flats for sale with a land value of each flat of 1598 USD/sqm. On average, the companies invested USD 21 million in each project expecting an average profit of 36% of this initial investment. Each project has specifications that are summarised in Table 1.10.1.

The analysis of each project is exhaustive and requires significant time in reconstructing line items, projected flows, sizing spaces, and reviewing this process in the light of a serial financial evaluation. It is important to note that these studies do not necessarily indicate the final earnings of each project, but rather the projections of expectations that can be developed and, ultimately, what financiers expect to earn when they engage in a real estate project. The synthesis of these financial flows can be seen in Table 1.10.2.

It is observed that the projects are highly profitable in their design of initial flows, with rates of return that on average give a 60.52% profitability, while at the same time projecting revenues of an average of approximately five million dollars. Table 1.10.3 assesses whether the inhabitants of each commune where projects are built can afford the cost of living in these apartments. The estimation is based on data from the National Socioeconomic Characterisation Survey of the Ministry of Social Development, which indicates the average household income according to the corresponding socioeconomic decile. From this data, it is established

Table 1.10.1 Cases studied and general synthesis of data.

Districts	Independencia 1	Santiago 1	Santiago 2	Independencia 2	Estacion Central	Independencia 3	Santiago 3	Ñuñoa
Land value (USD/sqm)	544	225	375	113	525	334	263	225
Constructed Area (sqm)	52,495	41,935	20,623	38,473	34,977	15,343	21,545	34,854
Stories (n)	26	31	24	25	30	19	21	25
Apartments to sale (n)	1,065	571	488	663	725	378	326	500
Apartments value (USD/sqm)	1,688	1,425	1,500	1,500	1,313	1,500	1,875	1,988
Expected income per sales (USD)	60,441,188	37,035,750	20,641,500	36,589,500	28,884,188	17,112,000	23,932,500	36,458,700
Total investment (USD)	33,412,500	23,793,750	14,953,432	21,262,500	19,237,500	10,125,000	14,175,000	31,266,000

Source: author based on information from the Environmental Assessment Service and InCiti.com.

Table 1.10.2 Financial evaluation of projects.

Districts	Independencia 1	Santiago 1	Santiago 2	Independencia 2	Estacion Central	Independencia 3	Santiago 3	Ñuñoa
Incomes	60,441,187.5	37,035,750	20,641,500	36,589,500	32,185,237.5	17,112,000	23,932,500	36,458,700
Expenditures	-40,582,575	-28,652,025	-14,736,975	-27,534,825	-24,852,825	-11,433,450	-15,536,587.5	-23,764,987.5
NPV	11,510,625	3,575,437.5	3,119,437.5	4,302,862.5	3,186,862.5	3,302,700	5,031,862.5	7,446,975
IRR	73.00 %	36.51 %	55.80 %	44.67 %	37.64 %	74.80 %	87.01 %	74.71 %

Source: author.

Table 1.10.3 Purchase rate for investment by project analysed in each commune.

Districts	Average price of a 2 bedroom monthly apartment rent cost	Average	Average monthly income per household per decile for 3 to 4 inhabitants per house or 4 people per house									
			1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Santiago	76,800	365	281	496	689	757	961	1,143	1,371	1,857	2,360	3,448
Estación Central	63,000	299	372	507	731	892	1,014	1,477	1,557	1,782	2,916	6,995
Independencia	75,000	356	218	400	738	1,204	1,289	1,328	1,301	1,448	1,911	3,625
Nuñoa	95,400	453	251	614	593	875	1,003	1,096	1,527	2,166	3,099	5,593

AU: Please provide significance for bold emphasis.



that a healthy household economy should not spend more than 25% of monthly income on the payment of costs related to renting or dividends for mortgage loans. According to the evaluated evaluation applied, these apartments would only be accessible to 20% of the highest income earners in each commune, with the exception of Estación Central, where the apartments would be accessible to 40% of the highest income earners. In no case are these new housing units affordable for the lowest 50% of income earners in each commune. Details of these findings are summarised in Table 1.10.3, where affordability per socioeconomic decile is highlighted with an asterisk.

Discussion

The results in the tables are indicative of the importance of the urban design process to have methodological tools to financially understand the socio-spatial impacts of its decisions. In the cases studied, the production of unaffordable housing for the neighbours of the projected buildings is the seed for the development of gentrification and displacement processes. As Cuthbert argues, urban design cannot ignore the economic factors behind its practice (A. Cuthbert, 2010; A. R. Cuthbert, 2006, 2011). Financial literacy is tremendously useful for urban designers not to become complicit in processes of socio-spatial deterioration. In the case of Santiago, the city has been nominated by the OECD as the most segregated among the member countries (OECD, 2013). Also, different processes of precarisation of the urban fabric as a result of free-market urban planning have been identified in the literature (R. Hidalgo et al., 2008). Gentrification and displacement are also indicated as the results of years using this neoliberal urban design approach (Contreras & Venegas, 2016; Lopez-Morales, 2011, 2016). Most of the literature here referred to the case of Santiago and points out the social effects of the neoliberal urban development process. Recent evidence indicates the statistical significance of financial institutions over housing prices and urban form in this metropolis (J. F. Vergara-Perucich, 2021a; J. F. Vergara-Perucich, 2021b). Thus, it would be desirable to include a financial agency in the curricular training of urban designers and architects, to identify predatory pricing, potential displacement, and gentrification processes before construction work begins.

AU: Please provide significance for bold emphasis.



For Roberts and Ng (2012), an agency relationship is a contract under which one or more persons engage another person to perform some service on their behalf, which involves delegating some decision-making authority to the agent. In this case, the agency comes from the financiers to the urban designers in developing a profitable product for their rent claims. By positing the importance of a financial agency for urban designers, the aim is to provide

knowledge embedded in the design of urban products that not only looks at the goodness of numbers for those investors but can also assess the social impacts of such products. In this way, a financial agency can be produced when urban designers are able to explain to their financiers that there are other ways of renting without falling into the search for maximum capital gain that harms the common good.

Urban design under neoliberalism was made possible, in part, by the financial illiteracy of urban designers, who uncritically adopted rent-seeking from projects as their own objectives, without understanding the impacts on the common good of this mode of operation (Boano & Perucich, 2017; Brites, 2017; Christodoulou & Lada, 2017; Encinas et al., 2019; R. Hidalgo et al., 2014; Letelier-Troncoso et al., 2019; Theodore et al., 2009; F. Vergara-Perucich, 2019; F. Vergara-Perucich & Boano, 2020b). To strip neoliberalism from the disciplinary practice of urban design, it is key to move towards a financial literacy of practitioners that allows them to the agency for the common when facing investors and authorities.

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